

PAWAN BHAWAR



JAI KAPADIA, BUSINESSMAN. He got his licence in August and is off to France to train on Airbus.

"I wanted to join the air force when I was a child."

ing to night to notch up her required 200 hours. Earlier this year, she returned from Toulouse after a type-rating on an Airbus to join Kingfisher Airlines as a co-pilot, where she is now a regular on the Mumbai-Chennai route.

Two other clear trends emerging in the great pilot boom are, the rapidly falling age of an entry-level pilot and a large number of women entering this male

bastion. Bavicca Bharathi, 18, who will shortly fly as a co-pilot can hope to be a commander even before she turns 25. "It is a very paying profession but clearly there are other inducements like leisure time, as pilots fly only 15-16 days a month," says Ajai Singh, managing director, Spicejet.

The rush of new recruits—an estimated 4,000 Indian students are training in flying schools in the US, Australia and the Philippines—will considerably ease the shortage. "The situation at the co-pilot level has considerably improved but on the commander side (pilots with at least 3,000 flying hours), it will take some time," says Singh. The flip side of this boom is the very real prospect of being grounded. An airline pilot's job demands physical and mental fitness of the highest order. Co-pilots undergo medical examination at least once a year while captains or ATPL holders have to undergo physical and mental tests every six months. "The job pays well, but your career lives from one medical to another, any dip in fitness means an end to your career," says a pilot of an international carrier. Pilots can fly up to the age of 65 and have long careers, but they are also under constant scrutiny by DGCA. One fault can ground a pilot, allowing him to fly only after being absolved in an inquiry, which could take months.

Clearly, no one is thinking about sundown in this sunrise industry, just yet.

114 airline transport pilot licences (ATPL or aircraft commanders). Though DGCA does not have the breakup of the exact number of second-career pilots, flying schools and aviation agents representing foreign training schools say over 10 per cent pilots are from other professions. "Of the 140 pilots we trained last year, 17 had opted for a shift in their careers," says Captain Yashraj Tongia, chief flying instructor of private flying club Yash Air.

Part of the lure has to do with the training duration—it takes just 10 months to get a licence. A pilot can peak in five to seven years, i.e., a captain can hope to get a monthly salary of Rs 5 lakh. "High salaries are a function of demand and supply. In the 1990s you had many changing their careers to become software engineers, now more and more people want to

become pilots. The supply is going to stabilise only over the next two years and salaries will stay at the present levels," says Sandeep Shenoy, strategist with PINC Research.

For Aneka Jesudason, 32, who slogged to obtain her MBBS degree before working in a private hospital in Hyderabad, the career switch was not a difficult choice. "The salaries we were being paid after so many years of hard work were pathetic," she says. So she took a three-month break from work to enroll in a flight training school in the US where she flew from morn-

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